

wired up, just prop the laptop at an appropriate place and power it up to access the network. You can work from where you get a spot to sit! The corporates we spoke to were impressed by this, and considered their business requirements that demanded access to the LAN and the Internet at all possible places.

It's not that expensive either—with laptop prices crashing and Wi-Fi hardware becoming affordable, implementation costs have reduced drastically.



How they did it

LRM got Convergent Communications, a systems integrator, to set the network up. Both, Harish Chandra, Area Information Systems Manager, LRM, and Rajiv Giri, Deputy General Manager, Convergent Communications have an interesting anecdote. “We charged in the same time as the housekeeping people, and stayed there as long they did!”, says Giri. He goes on to say, “It's not difficult to set up a Wi-Fi network, but doing that without tearing apart the furnishings, while the hotel is running with guests all over, was quite a challenge!”

Other problems also cropped up. “The window panes at LRM have a metallic coating to reflect sunlight and so, signals kept dropping when connecting to an AP located on the other side of the glass”, says Giri. Convergent worked around this by using more access points.

Chandra recounts, “We couldn't give them the run of the place, and the guests couldn't have the sound of drills and hammers disturbing them, so it was done very discreetly”.

Discreet is the word here—if you walk around LRM looking at the decorated walls, you can't see any APs. The only ones you can, are those kept in the open near the poolside.

Setting up a WLAN in other environments isn't that troublesome, since most of the cabling exists due to wired LANs. When asked about any installation problems,

Prashant Jain, Director, Pathways International School said that they weren't any. He says that they tied up with IBM Global Services for the network's design and implementation. Shoppers' Stop implemented their WLAN alongside their existing LAN.

Anand Mehta, Marketing Manager, D-Link India, says that initially, APs gave them a less-than optimal throughput when they set up their WLANs in 2001. Mehta says, “During the first few days, users were unhappy with the range.” However, the techs quickly figured out that raising the height of the AP to seven ft solved the problem. They then recalculated the optimal number of APs on each floor. Today, the users are more than satisfied and their head office, and several other branches are Wi-Fi enabled.

“Setting up Wi-Fi networks,” says Giri, “starts with a full-scale site survey, where the entire structure and environment are studied, after which we design and implement the solution”.

The people we spoke to pointed out that the actual network setup, including locating an ideal site for the APs was a breeze—just walk around with laptops, check signal strengths from different locations and then fix upon a good location.

Getting the associated infrastructure in place was, of course, dependant on



HARISH CHANDRA, Area Information Systems Manager, Le Royal Meridien, Mumbai

We have had a lot more customers, ever since we started offering Wi-Fi connectivity to our guests

whether the office already had it. If it didn't, it meant additional work.

In terms of hardware, laptops need an add-on Wi-Fi PCMCIA card, while desktops need a PCI Wi-Fi card. Centrino laptops come with inbuilt Wi-Fi networking capabilities. The existing infrastructure in most corporate environments makes it easier to add the cabling needed to connect APs.

Sify Chief Communication Officer, David Appasamy, says that while putting up hotspots at key locations in Bangalore, they used the infrastructure existing in iWay cyber cafés that were connected to their nationwide wired backbone. Direct line-of-



Secure Those Radio Waves

Security is a big issue. Both D-Link and Cisco—networking giants—have underscored the need to secure corporate wireless networks.

D-Link's Shridhar Kadam points out that since radio waves reach out everywhere, and travel through ceilings, floors and walls, “Without stringent security in place, installing a WLAN is the equivalent of putting up Ethernet ports everywhere”. Both, D-Link and Cisco agree that the relatively static encryption keys of Wireless Equivalent Privacy (WEP) are not that secure, and urge using Wi-Fi Protected Access (WPA) for corporate networks.

Cisco's Devendra Kamtekar says that it's possible to secure a Wi-Fi network with WPA.

There's also the emerging WPA2 standard that's expected to give still better security.

Appasamy talks of 'sophisticated security practices' being used for the company's hotspots. He says that accessing the hotspot, and getting online through Sify will be possible only through a stringent user-authentication procedure.

Isolating the wired and wireless networks, based on the requirement, may also help. In LRM, Chandra and Giri worked out the network in such a way that the wired internal staff network is totally isolated from the WLAN used by guests.

Pathways hasn't had any such security incidents, and Jain quips, “Until now, we have been fortunate!”